

The Top 10

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

Wellbeing. “Operating in a global context fundamentally changes your vantage point. You begin to see the world through a wider lens and understand cultural diversity, varied market dynamics and different ways of thinking,” she says. The exposure has turned out to be invaluable. “It broadened my perspective, strengthened adaptability and reinforced the importance of inclusive leadership in business success across geographies,” says Nair. More simply, both experiences taught her that growth comes from stepping out of one’s comfort zone. In this case, it was a combination of navigating the complexity of rural markets and embracing the global diversity of business.

From an India perspective, the story continues to excite everyone involved. The obvious pluses include fast-expanding GDP, improving per capita income, young demographic, and positive macroeconomic factors, to name a few. Nair speaks of the low per capita FMCG consumption as an indication of the potential that lies ahead.

“HUL has always mirrored India and, therefore, we are also transforming. It’s an exciting time to be here and run a consumer products business,” she says. Given HUL’s reach, it has the ability to witness that transformation at scale.

To Nair’s mind, rapid digitisation is a game-changer. She is quick to outline that HUL is leading this digital transformation—be it in end-to-end supply chain, distribution, the way it markets to consumers, or even the way consumers buy its products. “We are anticipating these shifts, shaping new habits, and leading market development to ensure we remain at the forefront of this journey for our company and the country. We have always maintained that what is good for India is good for HUL,” says Nair.

MAKING IT WORK

The strategy around premiumisation is apparent and she mentions it several times. In home care, it is through new formats such as detergent liquids and fabric conditioners. And in personal care, shaping habits is an opportunity. “For instance, body wash penetration in India is still under 2%. As a mar-

ket leader in soaps, we are driving the transition towards more contemporary formats like liquids,” she says.

Cut to beauty and wellbeing, HUL leads in skin, hair and colour cosmetics. Here, the giant’s ambition is to keep reshaping beauty regimes as India becomes more affluent, “moving consumers from simple routines to more complex ones,” which will remain central to HUL’s strategy.

Then, on the foods and beverages piece, there is Horlicks that occupies the health and fitness space. “We are also innovating with ready-to-drink formats and pro-fitness ranges to meet the growing demand for nutrition-forward products,” she says.

In every manner, it has been a homecoming for Nair, after four years spent overseas, first as Global CMO and later President (Beauty & Wellbeing), a business known to be quite challenging. “My experience in global markets like the US and China has underscored how rapidly the landscape can shift, especially with digital discovery at the forefront. In this environment, agility isn’t just an asset, it’s a necessity. The ability to adapt quickly and embrace new ideas is what keeps a business relevant and ahead of the curve,” says Nair.

Again, it is that cross-cultural exposure that often makes the difference. Nair says it shaped her approach to leadership. “I’ve seen firsthand how diversity and inclusion spark creativity and drive innovation. When people with varied experiences and perspectives

come together, they unlock new ways of thinking, fuel breakthrough innovation and build a culture that is resilient and future-ready,” she says.

Without a doubt, it brings in a global way of thinking but with a clear Indian touch. Quite possibly, it is this zeal of adaptability and reinvention that has placed her in the Top 10 ranking in *Business Today*’s Most Powerful Women in Business list. More importantly, the ranking awards her drive to transcend barriers to reach the highest echelons of leadership. **BT**

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